

Significant Entries from the Journal of Brother Stephan Dunmorrow
Envoy of Prelate Calvin Van Miserly of St. Ignatius

October 6, 1746

When I first woke today, I was happy to see that my long journey from the Seminary was coming to an end. Across a broad valley, I espied the Hedge, of which I was warned. My good man, Janvermin, sensed some comfort in me, and was quick to dispense with it.

“The Hedge of the Valdenwail” He said grimly, pointing as if I was as nearsighted as my thick spectacles make me seem. “It marks a new phase of our journey. And a phase you shall enjoy as much as the previous”.

The man is cheerful as a gallows keeper. He was right though.

We quickly packed up our austere camp, and headed through the valley and towards the hedge on the other side. This distance I greatly misjudged. It seemed to me a distance of perhaps a half mile. But my judgement was misguided by the size of the Hedge. Thinking it perhaps 20' high, I measured the valley thusly. And so it was that we had to cross a broad valley of *several* miles before our steep ascent up the decrepit road to the edge of that wall of brambles.

The hedge itself must be well over 100' high. Like any natural forest growth, it is thinnest and shortest at the edges. The road, such as it is, is overgrown by the encroaching Hedge at many places, and we were forced to veer off our course several times, and Janvermin had to find our way back. He is good at what he does, though, and we were never waylaid long before he had us marching over top of the ancient stones that form this once-proud road.

After a couple hours of this winding and trail blazing, we came to the densest part of the hedge. By this time, the road was a little better, and as we progressed, the Hedge around us became thicker and more sinister looking; large and wickedly curved thorns decorate the cheerless Hedge trees. One cannot pass anything larger than a hand into the hedge at this point, without sustaining many lacerations.

This thickness and impassability of the hedge is, at this point, marked by its vast height as well. The hedge is certainly over 100' high, but only at some points is it possible to take a sounding of its height, for it is mostly like a tunnel; the grim coppice forming a vaulted tunnel, sometimes just barely over our heads, sometimes many scores of feet above us. Most times, the light of day is so thoroughly obstructed and diffused that one would think it the twilight hour. At some points it is pitch darkness. Still, at times, the canopy opens up, and sunlight falls, and it is much like taking a deep draught of air after a long submersion in a cold and inky lake.

I should say that the path is by no means straight. I doubt very much that we followed one tract of that gloaming grotto that stayed its course for more than 100 yards before an

obtuse change in course presented itself. At many times, the conduit of the Hedge diverged from the ancient stones, only to find the venerable path again after several twists and turns.

Though we did not uncover any forks in the road, we did espy on two separate occasions, something which made us think we were nearing our destination. The first time, to the left of us, we saw some light struggling to penetrate the sable undercroft, and after a protracted bout of straining scrutiny, both I and Janvermin spotted a grey stony structure through the Hedge. We thought we would soon be coming to the Wall that I had been told of, which marks the halfway point of the veiled journey through that joyless furrow. However, the meandrous thoroughfare went soon to the right, and it was long before our next sighting.

Several hours later we again noticed, through and uncommonly thinned, yet still inexplicably obstructive, portion of the Hedge, a length of grey stony wall. This time, we were both able to make out an archway in what was clearly a man-made, though ancient, wall. It was perhaps 50' into the Hedge. I asked my man;

“Perhaps we are meant to carve our way to that bit of stone there, Vermin?”

His look was blank. He looked about briefly, and shrugged his shoulders - an uncommon response from him, to be sure.

“What do you think, man?” I demanded of him.

“I am ashamed to own, Sir,” he replied “I am quite out of my sounding. I have long ago lost track of our direction, and I am no longer even certain of the time of day.”

“Finding the time, at least, takes less skill than a leathery wanderer possesses...” I began. I took my timepiece out of my shirt pocket, and to my horror, I noticed that it had become unwound. It should have been good for a day or two, at least, before it needed winding again. Perhaps this was a coincidence, but I begin to think, now especially, that it was not.

“Well, then!” I commanded myself. “We continue on. Though I have read almost all there is to read of this Hedge and the Valdenwail itself, I have read no tales of forestry efforts or the like. We continue down this crepuscule path!”

Brave words just then. Thinking back on those Hedge-hidden blocks of stone has certainly fueled my imagination. Whatever could those buildings be used for? By whom? How does one arrive at them? How long is it since they have seen the sight of Men?

After those mysterious structures, the path became more serpentine and increased in its opacity for the next several hours, until at last, we were sure that darkness had fallen on the Natural World outside of this confounding Hedge.

We have now made what camp we can. I am thankful, just now, for Janvermin's expertise and circumspection. He had filled all of our skins with fresh water in the nape of the valley before the aperture of the Hedge. I was too excited to tend to such minutiae, but after such a journey, we are both in need of replenishment.

If I never saw pitch blackness before, I have tonight. Our camp is of such a stygian nature, as to make me suspect that cheer and light were but tricks of the mind; falsely remembered and unconceived in fact.

October 7

Today brought more hope with it, but ended with less.

When we both agreed that it must be somewhere around daybreak, we packed up and made our way. We were not convinced of our reckoning for some time; the vault of the Hedge was close in about us for a couple hours (if time exists in such a piceous void as this portion of the Hedge), and we saw no hint of light all that time. Finally, though, the way became more cavernous, and through the brambles above, we again saw light. Such was my joy at the sight of those wan cobbles ahead of us that it was long before I noticed the condition of my guide.

My good man, Janvermin, had been using what little light we had with us (some candles and one anemic lantern which burns more oil than it casts light) to find our way. But he had been using his hands to find our way in some of the more nigrous and sigmoid portions of the journey, and he was covered in wicked lacerations too numerous to tabulate. I implored him to stop so that I could dress his wounds.

Upon cleaning the wounds with what little water we could spare, I noticed that they were grossly inflamed as well. I am no Doctor of Medicine, but I know a dangerous wound when I see one, and he has scores. Already, he has developed a cough and a pallor that worries me.

At any rate, we continued on. The day was full of the same findings as yesterday; the meandering conduit within the Hedge, sometimes following the ancient and worn cobbles, sometimes not, rare sightings of structures, perhaps forgotten by all but us, through this swart nettle.

Finally, though, the road and the path widened, and we followed a straight path up a hill for several hundred yards. The road here, though grown over considerably, revealed some particularly large stones that had engravings of all manners of things upon them. At a few spots along the way, the broken remnants of old statues of many sizes, now covered in the same bracken as the rest of the land, evoked disconsolate images of a great Empire, erstwhile and unremembered. I wanted to examine some of the carvings and statues, but Janvermin would abide none of my distractions. Today, I did not argue with him. He is now a sick man.

That steep approach is bathed in a wan light, as the gorse above is presumably not so thick. Towards the top of the hill, we were able to see quite clearly, a stone wall which obstructed our path, and a great archway in that wall through which we might pass. As before, I misjudged the size of that which I observed. The wall and the archway seemed to get no nearer with my first many steps, until it seemed like we were marching up a most unnatural hill, which checked our progress. But it was long after apparent that the hill was just longer and higher than I thought, as was the wall, and the width of the very road leading to it. Though this misconception is partly due to clever engineering and tricks of scale and perspective, it is also largely due, I am sure, to the unnatural and oppressive nature of the Hedge, and it's adeptness for inspiring confusion and doubt.

At length, we came to the top of the hill, and found ourselves before a great wall and a great archway. I should think that it may have been a veritable splendour of the ingenuity, industry and will of Men, if the wall and the aperture could be seen in the unobstructed light of day. But, though some little light did come through the furze above, it was still no brighter than a cloudy twilight. Details and convolutions upon the wall and the archway there were aplenty. Too many, in fact, to get a focus on one, for the first-time-observer of this magnificent and cyclopean structure. I should have liked to stay a while and recorded some of them. There is an entire encyclopedia of information and history in that archway, I am sure. But, it was not to be. For starters, my guide would not have permitted a lingering. But it was our new company that hastened things along.

For, we were not alone under that prodigious structure. Under the archway stood a trio of sentinels, as quiet as they were dark. We were both quite frightened when we saw them, and no one stirred a fig for quite some time. I confess that I went through a series of thoughts and emotions. The figures, under that enormous archway, looked like toy soldiers beneath a more commonly sized archway. They provoked fear at first, but then doubt; I thought that perhaps they were statues, so still they stood. But then I *knew* that they were living things, of a stamp. They did not move or make noise or give any other indication to the observer of their prescience, but they did inspire one to realization and further fear.

Finally, after many exchanged glances and whispers between us, Janvermin and I approached the trio of sentinels. That they are of a human proportion and configuration is a good place to begin my description of them. They are adorned with the trappings of men, ancient though they are. There, their likeness to living, breathing men stops.

These sentinels stand about as large as the largest of men. They are clad in bronze armour so old and thick with grime of ages as to appear black in all but the most elevated of reliefs. Their armour is the plate variety that one can now find in museums and the halls of the warlike Saints and Nobles; it covers every possible bit of flesh, and is so bulky and heavy that it was, in its day, more of a liability than an asset, and has thus been replaced by lighter armours in our times. The begrimed armour is covered, on all surfaces, by very intricate relief. I have not had the opportunity, as one could well imagine, to clean and inspect one of these suits properly, but even though the grit of a

dozen centuries chokes those friezes, I could plainly see that the armour *was* beautiful, and that each suit must have a great story to tell.

But that is neither here nor there. The issue at hand was salutations, and those were of the most unusual variety I have ever experienced, and hope never to experience again. I remember a time, during my Investiture at the Seminary, that some of my fellow students would sing the most salacious song. It was entitled *Lonely Sister Rebecca Tuck*, and it was full of all the obvious limericks you might expect from such a title. Anyway, there were verses that would stick in my head for days at a time, and it felt like a veritable intrusion into my own mind. Meeting the sentinels was much the same. That they spoke directly inside my head, I don't doubt, though it was not the same as hearing one speak with a corporeal tongue. I was given the distinct impression by the sentinels that I would not be able to pass without some explanation as to my business in the Valdenwail.

I croaked out an explanation. "Sirs; my apologies for intruding upon your most serene and amicable home. I am Brother Stephan, Envoy from the Seminary of St. Ignatius, and I come bearing a marked letter from His Most Enlightened Prelate Van Miserly, to be delivered to the hands of the Scion of St. Avitus, and none other." I remember looking at my toes the whole time I delivered this speech, and the shiny creases on the folds of the worn leather of my shoes.

I was then aware that I was free to pass, but that Janvermin was not. I stammered a plea for him to accompany me, but it was met with a wall of obstinate will, and I knew that he could not pass. He knew it too.

"I will go down the hill, and await your return" Janvermin said to me through his weak coughs. "I do not wish to wait under the gaze of these things, and under the maw of this wall. I wish you well. Though this place is foreboding, I feel you have safe leave. If they wished you harm, it would have been done to you already. Fare you well, Envoy"

I nodded a weak nod, and approached the sentinels. Finally they moved; they pivoted on one heel, and pointed into the archway, to the gloom beyond. And then, one by one, they turned back to their previous resolute stance.

I journeyed past the sentinels, leaving Janvermin behind. He has been in my mind all the rest of this dreary and trying day. For the Gate is but the halfway point in the Hedge, if what I have read is true, and I have at least 2 days to spend, clawing through this caliginous bramble, before I am delivered from it.

October 12

Today, or rather, tonight, I have emerged from the Hedge, not 2 days, but several, since the Gate. I scarcely noticed that I had emerged, as it is a moonless and overcast night, and light is but a memory to me again. I have a few scratches from the Hedge, and my mind is on fire half the time, and dreamy the other half. Now, with a hint of breeze in my hair, I again feel like I have command of my senses, though I have not these past several

days. I feel like I have just woken up from a very long bout of sleep walking through a nightmare.

October 13

It is first thing in the morning, and though it is raining and dismal, the grey sky has a hint of lithium where the sun is hidden, and I know that I am free of the Hedge. Before me is a rolling moor, with a lonely road of ancient cobblestones tracking a path through the downcast countryside. The moor is very boggy at this point, but there are some patches of bright green growth at the peaks of some small hills, and their colour is the only hope I have seen in this entire Ecclesiarchy. The wind is strong, but refreshing. It has the smell of the ocean that I was told to expect, though I had never smelled myself.

Later on...

I spent all day in my solitary travel down the old road, and have seen not a soul. The road is broad, and many of the stones, like some of those before the Gate, have been carved with friezes and words. The language is clearly Old Imperial, though much of it is interspersed with older characters that I cannot discern. I have made drawings of some of them, but the weather is too foul for such business, and I must make haste.

Tonight, I make my lonesome camp under a large rock on top of a hill. I found a little stream, and have filled my flasks and drunk, and feel coherent and well for the first time in days.

Though I feel well, I wonder how poor Janvermin is faring. Already, I am far behind schedule. We estimated 2 more days in the hedge, 2 days to the Valdenwail, a day there, and 4 back to the Gate. I have been 5 days emerging from that damnable Hedge. I hope that Janvermin has both patience and health to hold.

October 14

Today has been drizzly all day. The soggy skies seem satisfied to deliver as little moisture as possible, to protract its irrigous business as long as possible. The wind blows right into my face as I continue in what I now think is a south-easterly direction. It has been increasing its fierceness all day, and the organic smell of the ocean is growing stronger.

I saw people for the first time today. They were very distant, perhaps the better part of a mile away, and several hills removed from the road. They seemed to have a small flock of sheep or some other animal with them. We looked at each other for a long time across a hilly lowland, and at length I decided to approach them. I was not certain what I would have to say to a bunch of rustic shepherds (in any part of the world, let alone this bygone country), but I was in need of *any* human interaction. I think I would have settled for a beating from them, if they would have it.

They wouldn't. By the time I got to their previously espied location, they were gone. I must confess that I doubted my sanity at that point. I worried that I was imagining people, and shepherds at that! But no; I have spent enough time on the road with Janvermin to know to look at it once in a while, and sure enough, there were plenty of tracks of both men and beasts, and I was satisfied that I was not insane, but rather unsavoury company for these folks, and set back to my trail.

October 15

I am camped at the gates of the Valdenwail, and won't be admitted tonight. Such execrable hospitality I have never encountered, in even the most anonymous of bywaters.

The day began with a continuation of the doleful weather for which I have now come to associate with this dispiriting Ecclesiarchy. A deliberate march through the rolling hills brought me alternatively from the boggy swales, to the wind-blasted heaths of this woebegone moor. As the march progressed, I became aware that I was climbing higher and higher, and the nadirs of the rolling moor became tolerably moist the further I went, though the bitter wind became fiercer upon those unwelcoming zeniths.

I should say a thing about the road at this point. The road follows a very irregular course, and there are at many points, ancient junctions that lead to Sodor's Door for all I know. It is only by the lasting and antediluvian virtue of the map which I copied from the *Magnus Corpus Avitus* that I was able to make my way to my final destination. The road is confounding, to be sure, though, and I had to 'back track' (as Janvermin would call it) many times. The road leading to the Valdenwail itself is unmistakable though; all of the secondary arteries which I found myself walking down soon proved to be of an even more senescent and disused nature, if a magnitude of age and neglect greater than that of the primary thoroughfare can be imagined. I confess that it makes my head swim to think of such ancient roads, once so large and well constructed, becoming so old and timeworn as to be all but forgotten. What once happened upon those quondam arteries of Empire?

One veritably stumbles into the Valdenwail, if it can be imagined. In the last league before the ancient acropolis, the approach becomes very difficult. The land becomes very stony and mountainous, with very little vegetation of any variety beyond nasty fungi, and the road at this portion of the journey has been carved out of the rock itself; it is much like a trough in the stone, and at many points, crumbling bulwarks rise above the edge of the trough, and stare down menacingly, like an old man with no teeth, at the weary traveler on that compromised road. This rocky flume has certainly been carved out of the now-mountainous country for a dual purpose; it allows some semblance of ease of navigation through what would now otherwise require the aide of a seasoned mountaineer, but it also provides a quite compromised position for any invader that might come up this road. Certainly, the *MCA* makes reference to the 'Upper Channel', which is inaccessible to those on the 'Lower Channel', though the lower traveler is at the mercy of those upon the Upper.

At one junction in the Lower Channel, I did take my time to do some drawings. Here, the channel is some 100' wide, and relatively flat and smooth. The walls to either side are carved straight up out of the mountain, and rise some 80-100', so that I find myself standing in a magnificent concourse of illuminated stone, for the walls here are covered in friezes too numerous to count, and many as beautiful as the day they were chiseled from that unforgiving stone. Here, the elements are held at bay, somewhat, by a great precipice which rises hundreds of feet above the trough in its natural jagged fashion, and the salty winds blowing off the ocean have not smoothed the rock here as they have in many other parts of this journey. The flagstones themselves are a rich tapestry of history, and the walls are lined with statues of men and women and creatures that are forgotten by all save the most privileged and lore-stepped inhabitants of the Valdenwail.

The Channel at this point comes to an intersection; a secondary (by virtue of being smaller and heading back downhill at an obtuse angle) artery runs off the main course, so that the road here is somewhat 'Y' shaped. To the left, the road runs under a great arch which is suspended about 100' above the descending road. The arch is fantastic itself; for starters, it is nearly anachronistic in its architectural quality. I would not have suspected such delicate and lasting arches from the primeval architects and builders of this ancient place. The arch forms a covered bridge, of a type; a stony rampart of many levels and convolutions spans this 100' wide gap upon the arch, and this structure alone would be heralded as a great castle in any lands I have been, Waldheim included. When I got there, it was nearly eventide, though, and not one black window framed a hint of light. The sight of such a magnificent structure, so cleverly conceived, artfully constructed, graceful to behold, and seemingly impregnable, the sight of it in such a state of neglect and disuse made me so saturn that I nearly wept.

However, I knew that I was getting closer. The towers and battlements that rise above the carved-out trough became more frequent (though in no greater condition of repair or use) and much more impressive. The journey became much steeper as I went along as well, and I had to scramble over some debris at many points, presumably from depreciating battlements above me; by this time, it was quite dark and the rain had become quite fierce. A great howling was overhead as well, and occasionally a thunderous whistling (one really must hear it to agree that this description, while seemingly oxymoronic, is actually accurate) came down the Channel accompanied by stinging blasts of the salty, acrimonious gale.

Finally, though, at the peak of a steep climb, I found myself under another great archway, this one like a great two-pronged fork, with great towers rising well over 100' above the archway which is suspended across the 80' deep Channel. Steep bluffs rise to either side of the archway and the towers, and I could vaguely make out the dark arches of what must be the Upper Channel, where it runs as a tunnel through one rocky bluff, across a small arch to one tower, across the greater arch, through the other tower, across another small arch, and into another dark tunnel in the opposite bluff. But it was not this detail of the ancient architecture which caught my focus, for before me is the Valdenwail.

The ascent to this peak is so high and steep that you cannot have any notion that such an amazing acropolis is just on the other side, waiting to surprise you like a bandit hiding behind a great fallen log. As you climb this last bit of this unhappy road, you are compelled to take in the twin towers, which I believe are named *Gromhaufel* and *Zuirenhahst*, so that the vista beyond the zenith is sprung like a trap. Add to this contrivance of the clever and ancient architects, the merciless winds which come straight off the ocean and up to this peak, racing for your exposed and tender flesh like coursing hounds for the hare, which force you to recoil and make your redoubt before you can again look out, and you find yourself at a loss of initiative, to be sure.

When I did finally recover from the elements, having bundled up tight and shrinking my head into my shoulders as well as I may, I looked out, and was robbed of breath. The Valdenwail was right there, not 200 yards down a gently sloping section of the trough, and it terminated the trough as sure as a spade through a snake. I shall try to describe what can be seen of the Valdenwail from this vantage;

To begin, this portion of the rocky land becomes more gentle; it is less than a mile from beneath the arch of the two towers to the cliff that drops off to the Sea which forms the Valdenwail's most resolute southern boundary, and this expanse is mostly a benign plateau, for the most part free of the rugous mountains through which the traveler has just emerged. From the archway, there is a gentle slope downwards towards the Valdenwail which broadens from its span of about 100' under the arch, to perhaps a mile at the foot of the bulwark of the Valdenwail. On either side of this gentle descent, the rocky eminence rises nearly straight up like a jagged wall. The plateau upon which the Valdenwail has stood for so many centuries is perhaps 7 miles from east to west, and the thickest parts of the sprawling and ancient acropolis might be as wide as 1 and one half miles from the southern cliff to the northern mountain which makes its borders. In the middle, which is roughly where I find myself now, the Valdenwail is at its thinnest, being only perhaps 200 yards from bulwark and gate to the southern cliff, so that the unimaginably large place has the shape, roughly, of a kidney bean with a very narrow middle.

The plateau is also very lunate, curving away sharply from the narrow middle, so that I can see the face of the steep cliff and the great walls that sit upon it at the eastern- and western-most reaches, and how those walls have the seeming of something that has grown from the rock, rather than having been hewn from it, or stacked upon it, so long have they cohabitated together. Now that I think of it, if one was to imagine the seagull's view of this place (though there are fewer of those than one would expect to find around a seaside castle of any size, let alone this one) I suppose it would look much like a gentleman's bow-tie in shape.

The Valdenwail rises slightly towards its eastern and western extremities, and at its edges it has crept up the sides of the steep rock that borders the plateau, so that thousands of empty windows and archways, and hundreds of balconies and small towers, decorate the lower reaches of those impassable bluffs which frame the plateau. The Valdenwail chokes every square inch of the plateau, save for the open approach from the two towers

to the main Gates below. The approach, here as with much of the Lower Channel, is bordered by the steep walls that have been hewn out of the stone, upon which the bulwarks and small towers of the Upper Channel sit, abandoned, watching with sightless eyes for erstwhile enemies.

After crossing about 200 yards down the yawning approach to the illimitable fortress-city, I find myself at the Gates of the Valdenwail. At this point, the great wall rises up before me, and stretches in its incongruous and convoluted manner, from one precipice to the other. At its lowest point, the wall must be 60' or perhaps less, but well over 200' in some of the highest portions of this mile and a half long battlement. There are towers every 100' or so, and they are of a great variety of styles, shapes and sizes. One thing is consistent in the architecture of what I have seen of the Valdenwail so far, though; the ubiquitous greenish-grey stone from which it has been built. I have no doubt that this stone that has been quarried from the vast trench which runs for such a great distance approaching the acropolis; the walls of the Lower Channel are of this same sickly hue.

At the centre of the great wall is the unmistakable Portis Primus of the acropolis. A great tower over 200' in height, and covered in smaller balconies and towers like an ancient tree covered with countless hoary burls and clinging lunate fungi, dominates the centre of the wall. At its base, an archway stands like a great letter 'm', with a pillar the size of which I have never encountered elsewhere, supporting the middle. The double-archway is over 100' high, and to each side of the pillar, a 25' wide opening marks the entrance to the Valdenwail. That this tower is old beyond reckoning is doubtless. The stone is covered in a thick and shaggy green moss higher than the apex of the double arch, and above that, it is so worn from centuries of this merciless weather as to be polished to a shine.

I should say at this point that images in my mind of an Empire of great vastness and power did come flooding in. How much effort does it take to create such a structure as this, so prodigious and ornate? How many thousands of lives of men were spent to build this peerless expanse of towers and arches and battlements and countless and untold things unseen? As I approached the Gates, I had visions of thousands of men going through those Gates, hauling huge blocks of stone, as large as a small house in, while thousands poured out to gather more. I had visions, too, of vast armies of mounted men, with great siege machines rolling ponderously behind, coming out of those proud Gates like sunlight through the clouds. But when I got close enough in this gloom to fetch a better look at them, my visions were sundered. Though the Gate Tower is certainly ancient, counting its years by millennia, it has been modified relatively recently. It is important to say 'relatively', for the newer stones of which I speak were certainly laid hundreds of years ago, likely about 400 years ago, if I am any student of History. The huge double aperture of the Gate Tower has been sealed almost entirely shut; large stone blocks have obstructed those twin maws, like so many bricked-over windows to be found in Waldheim. However, at the base of the easterly opening, a large wooden door stands in a new archway, some 8' wide and 12' tall; large enough for any activities that this castle now sees in its denouement.

There are three Armoured Guardians, nearly identical to those found at the Hedge Gate, standing in the great Tower Gate double arch which I have just described, and these three made the same supernatural contact with me as I approached. They seemed to expect me, and I sensed that I could approach the door. As I approached, one turned its armoured head to take me in. I could see no flesh beyond the slight opening of his full helmet, and though I could see my breath come as excited puffs of fog on this cold maritime eve, none issued forth from their helms.

The centre of the large door is adorned with a cast-iron ring about the size of a well tile, and it was only with great effort that I was able to swing it precariously back, and then strike the door with a resounding 'thud'. The castle is so large that I couldn't imagine that a doorman would be by any time soon, and, indeed, the sentinels seemed to suggest to me by way of their disquieting mental impressions, that I would have to wait for some time, and not strike the door again.

The next couple of hours were the worst I ever spent. I feared to stay too close to the door and the Sentinels, but feared to stray too far from it as well. When I became anxious, at times, and contemplated striking the door again, I was met with those same walls of resolute will that told me 'wait, and do not strike that door again'. So I waited, and paced, and tried to stay out of the gaze of the sentinels and in sight of the door all at once, which is a geographical impossibility and a great source of anxiety for me.

But, at last, the door opened. Or rather, a small aperture, heretofore unnoticed by this envoy, opened up in the door; it was a smaller door about 2' x 2', and I was immediately warned of it's opening by the pale flickering light that issued forth from it. I was startled, but gathered myself quickly, and stepped up as professionally as I am known to do, and began into my usual salutations, which were cut short before I had one syllable formed, by a very inelegant and loutish greeting from an unseen mouth;

"It is late! The Valdenwail will have no visitors this time of night!" and with that, the little door slammed shut.

Though the sentinels moved not an inch after this, I could feel their great Wills pressing down upon me, and knew that I could not press the issue further. I made a hasty and downcast retreat back up the gentle slope of the approach, and over the tempest-swept crest beneath the two towers, where I now write from.

I have a miserable camp tonight; everything I have is soaked thoroughly, and I don't think I have been more crestfallen in my entire life. It has been a challenging journey to get here, and though the sight of this matchless fasthold was uplifting beyond my expectations, it has made my disappointment all the more difficult to bear. And just now, I have thought of poor Janvermin, who is doubtless ill beyond bearing, and full of questions about my whereabouts. I am long overdue.

But, there is one thing that makes it bearable. Just after setting up my simple camp, I journeyed to the crest again, and took another long look at that sprawling bastion, and

though there are ten thousand black windows looking back at me, there are 4 yellow ones, and a little trail of smoke from a fire somewhere deep within the bowels of that impossibly huge acropolis.

October 16

I spent a horrible night, and will spend another likewise. Owing partly to my excitement at finally reaching the legendary Valdenwail, partly to my aches from a perilous journey, and partly from my limitless discomfort in what little shelter I could find from the tempest which raged on through the night, I slept not a wink. Shortly before sunrise, the rage of the elements withered to a dull and monotonous thudding of heavy rain, and little wind. Though I was soaked through and shivering from head to toe, I packed up, and perched myself at the crest beneath the arch of the two towers, and watched the Gates of the Valdenwail with an absent determination. I crouched like an animal, propped half against one wall of the trough, and moved not an inch for countless hours (my watch is still not working, and is now so hopelessly waterlogged that it will need the benefit of a visit to the watchmaker in Waldheim before it will keep time again). Though I moved not a bit of my frame, my eyes moved constantly from looking south at the Gates, to the east where I expected the sun to rise.

Eventually, what passes for a sunrise in this dismal Ecclesiarchy did perchance to present itself. It was a long and drawn out affair, and agonizing for the expectant viewer. I supposed that the sun would bring some warmth to my bones, and open the Gates for me, and so I watched expectantly, waiting anxiously for those warming rays. They never came. A pale grey light formed in the east, and it has not brightened all day. The clouds rolled slowly across the skies, from east to west, and though the sun did creep up over the mountains, it has not burnt its way through those obstructing clouds, and has delivered little light and no warmth to this land. I think these stones would abhor a condition of warmth and sun.

At any rate, when the sun was at a position in the sky behind the clouds that I took to indicate 8 bells, I again made my approach to the double arch of the Gates. The same three sentinels were still there in the same spot I left them last night, the time and rain seeming to have no affect upon their unflinching disposition. I was sure that I was going to receive nothing better than a scurrilous greeting from the brusque and unseen doorman from the night before, but I received less than that. As I approached, I could feel the weight of the Will of those sentinels upon me, and I knew that it was not yet time to ring the oversized knocker. I slowed my approach, and turned back.

For several hours, I tread the path from the crest beneath the two towers, to the Gates of the Valdenwail, and upon each approach, I was repelled by the will of the Sentinels. I watched that pale obstructed glow arc slowly up, and then quickly down. Long after the faded lithium of the concealed sun was past its zenith, and fast approaching the peaks of the mountains to the west, I steeled myself, and approached the relatively diminutive wooden door of the Gates. This time, too, the Will of the sentinels bore down upon me, but I was determined to do my job, and though I struggled with my own fears and their

unspoken threats, I did finally reach that enormous knocker, and my cold-numbed hands managed to rock it back a few inches, which was enough for it to resound as clearly as it had last night. Upon the report from this ludicrous implement of greeting, all three of the sentinels turned slightly to face me, and their Wills pressing down upon me were like a black avalanche. But, I stayed my position, and defiantly faced the small portal in the door beneath the knocker from which I expected my unfriendly greeting.

After about an hour of standing there, shifting my weight and courage uncomfortably, the small portal in the door did open suddenly. It is only at about chest height, and I had to bend down to look into it to face my greeter. My greeter was doing likewise, and was clearly unhappy to be doing so. There was an old face on the other side of the door, and it showed perhaps 50 years, perhaps 100, it was difficult to tell. It was not likely a pretty face in its youth either; only one yellow eye looked at me, while the other jaundiced orb wandered randomly like a dog in a park, whilst our short salutations were done. We sized each other up, and he snorted in contempt at the sight of me, and barked out his greeting;

“No visitors to the Valdenwail on the Feast of St. Oledan!” and with that the small door slammed shut on my face.

I felt dejected but not surprised. The three sentinels, sensing my defeated will, turned back to their original positions after their hour-long scrutiny of me, and though there was no physical evidence, and little supernatural impression, I could not but help feeling as though they wore smug smiles on whatever faces might be found beneath those flesh-eclipsing helms. I made my way back to my previous night’s camp, on the other side of the crest beneath the arch and two towers. It is here that I am sure I will die a slow death of exposure and tergiversation. “Feast of St. Oledan” indeed! I have never heard of such a Saint, and though I should be more modest, I am quite accomplished in my studies of the Saints at the Seminary. But then, here I am, camped out at the seat of the Saintly Faith in Avitus, where more knowledge has been hidden over the ages than can ever be guessed at. Who am I to doubt the existence of a Saint Oledan, or the veneration of this obscure Saint within the walls of the Valdenwail?

There is but one thing that disquiets me; before tonight, I could name 158 Saints and the dates of most of their veneration and ceremonies. Now, I can name 159, and though by the Grace of St. Ignatius, I wish to learn all I can of matters Saintly and otherwise, I hope that the callow concierge of the Valdenwail teaches me no more before I am lead to a fire and a bowl of warm food under a dry roof.

Already, my hand is too shaky to continue this book of days. I shall not write again before I am lead to warmth.

What of Janvermin?

October 20?

I must begin by bridging the gap in this chronicle. I spent four nights at least camped outside the Valdenwail, and they were all spent in misery. It may have been five nights, but I was so consumed by hunger and cold that I may have spent another unknown. I was wet and cold almost the entire time, until I resolved to go back to the sheltered intersection that I spoke of on the 15th. I knew the elements would not be as terrible there, and I was able to spend one night in comfort, and get some of my things dry. I did not want for water (in fact, I was in want of drought long before the door of the Valdenwail was opened to me), but I ran out of food on the 18th, and as I write tonight, I have a terrible rumble in my bowels from having eaten a terrible meal in too-few bites after too long a fast.

This morning, the 20th as best as I can tell, I was finally admitted to the Valdenwail. I was quite delirious and weak by the time the door was opened to me, and there are few details I can remember from that encounter. I do know the name of the man who has let me in though, as I have spent much of the day with him, and him only. If there is another soul living in the Valdenwail, I have no evidence of it.

Numble Evanshore is his name, and he calls himself by so many titles, from Door Warden to Executor, that certainly he must have a very long list of duties within the walls of this lorn acropolis. The man looks to be quite old, and in terrible health. With the exception of making quick and curt disallowances, he does nothing fast. He creaks and rattles along on knees that make more noise than rusty chains being dragged over a cobbled street, and the sound of his breathing reflects the moistness of the environment in which this place exists; surely his lungs are three parts full of fluid and poison and sickness, so that each breath is a struggle for the decrepit and pitiable thing, and the wheezing that follows each shrinking of his exsanguinous chest leaves a lump in my throat.

I was admitted to the place, and followed Numble through a dream. I would like to say that I mastered my discomforts, and took in the splendour of the fabled Valdenwail, but I did not. My first several hours within those hallowed walls were spent in a delirious stupour; my whole body had been soaked and chilled to the core, and indeed, to my brain, and I had no wit or senses beyond an instinct to follow Numble where ever he might be taking me. I am not sure how many hours we marched through that boundless labyrinth of superannuated stone, but at last, he brought me to the place I now write from.

I am now a resident of Dunvegan House. When I first arrived on the broad porch of this place, I had regained some little strength and warmth from my long walk through the acropolis. I noticed Numble struggling with a huge ring of keys of many different varieties, and he was saying to himself "Not an easy job, these days, being Key Deacon" and he let out such a lung-rumble that I thought he might die that instant. Where would I be then?

Anyway, he opened the door, and hobbled in, and made an irritated gesture for me to follow him. I did. He lit a single candle in the modest foyer, and spoke again.

“Dunvegan House. You will be our guest here and here only. There is logs and food in here.”

I began to muster myself for a delivery of my formal request to deliver my letter to the Scion, but Numble guessed I had something to say, and cut me off by waving both his hands at me in a feeble and tired dismissive gesture. “Save yer breath for billowing your fire, messenger. And don’t leave Dunvegan House”. He left, and he locked the door from the outside after he did. I am now a prisoner in the Valdenwail.

However, it is not a terrible incarceration. Though, perhaps I am just happy of any place that will shelter me from the relentless rains and wind that assault the Lower Channel and any luckless traveler thereupon.

After Numble left, I took the candle, and wandered through the dusty place, and found many more candles to light. I was so thankful of the small warmth and light that I lit every candle that I found, and those were thankfully many. This is a reasonably large place, though I am sure it has seen no guests in decades. The dust is thick upon every surface, and most of the furniture has been covered, though those coverings are now so moth eaten and threadbare that promontories on every piece can be seen peeking through the sheets.

My time on the road with Janvermin has again proven useful. After walking around the house searching for more candles to light, I noticed a track in the dust heading into a chambre that I had not yet been to. I cautiously entered the room, a lighted candle held aloft as my only weapon. The room was a kitchen, and it was empty of all life save mine. I followed the tracks to a large oak table, and thereupon I found a small sack of food and a bundle of sticks and one small log for a fire.

I am ashamed to own that I conducted myself like a beggar who has found a shilling, at that point. Upon discovering the food in the bag, I began to consume it in a most beastly manner, and it was this lapse in manners that earned me the gastric discomfort that I now own. At first glance, it seemed a rustic, though hearty meal; a couple of apples, a small wheel of cheese, some bread and a piece of thick dark meat. I ate the bread first, and had it all in my gullet before I noticed the dull acidic taste of mold in the back of my throat. It was strong enough to put me into a bout of coughing that might have rivaled Numble’s knells.

With no more dining caution than I practiced with the bread, I attacked the meat, tearing a mouthful from it and swallowing it down with little mastication. It stuck, and I paused. In this short pause, I took a moment to smell the morsel in my hand, and found it to be a very sub-comestible slab of foulness; it smelled like a leper’s foot, and was waxy as a corpse. I tried to hack up the piece stuck in the back of my throat, but somehow managed to swallow it down completely during my masticatory convulsions. It now rots in my

stomach, but it must have some virtue in it, for though I feel trembles in my depths, at least I have some feeling.

A quick examination of the apples found them waxy and soft, and the cheese...I shall not think on it further. There was one bottle of red wine though, and that, I confess, is the finest I have ever had. Perhaps they have put some sweet poison in it.

Because the sticks and log were in the kitchen, I decided to start a fire in the cooking hearth in this room, rather than bother with carrying them to a more comfortable chambre. This laziness is deplorable in a graduate of the Seminary of Saint Ignatius, but I feel that my constitution has been tried beyond reason, and this one lapse in effort should be excused. At any rate, it cost me more energy in the end; I found a very comfortable burgundy leather chair in a drawing room, and decided on dragging it into the kitchen to enjoy the warmth of the small fire. The chair was certainly heavier than the wood. But it could be that I have made the right decision. The kitchen is small, and it is now quite warm.

I am now nodding off, and this leather chair will be a fine bed.

Just now, though, I have thought again of Janvermin. My rest will not be too sound.

October 21?

I have seen no one today, but have had a reasonably eventful day despite my lonesome incarceration.

I awoke at...time is now lost completely to me. I am not sure of the time of day, nor the day itself. No sunlight penetrates this Archeronian Acropolis. I have explored Dunvegan House thoroughly, and have found all the windows one might expect in an Urban home of a well-to-do burgher, but there is no light beyond them. I thought that perhaps I had awoken at night, but at least a dozen hours have passed, and there is still no hint of light. I believe that even the streets of this place are completely covered over, and no light is permitted into the Valdenwail even upon the thoroughfares. There were rumours, heretical and controversial in the most severe nature, that one Scion in ages past was some form of Vampire, and had the entire place roofed over during a reign of hundreds of years. Though I cannot speak for the sanguinous character of the present Scion or any past, the streets are certainly covered, so that the Valdenwail is submerged in perpetual night.

Dunvegan House is four stories high, and was once well appointed. There are a score of bedrooms, numerous small turrets, two large entertaining rooms, one with an illuminated marble floor, a small theatre, several dining rooms, several kitchens, and numerous rooms besides. Though all the rooms were full of decorations and furnishings of a bygone opulence, covered and dusty though they were, it was the one room that had been robbed of its trappings that caught my attention, and provided a distraction from this protracted and trying service; the library. The library of Dunvegan House is a 2-story affair, and

might have held ten thousand books in its day. There are great expanses of wall with nothing to adorn them, and as these are the only glabrous walls in the House, I am led to believe that they once displayed maps. The multitudinous bookshelves were all but bare. I began to wonder if the *Repurgo Imperialis* managed to find its way into these walls as well. There is really no indication in any History I have studied to suggest one thing or the other. Perhaps it did. Or perhaps my graceful and courteous hosts have removed any information from this place that they think might offend the sensibilities of their unenlightened guests.

At any rate, they did not remove everything. I did find one book in a dark corner shelf, and this discovery urged me to further exploring. After hours of filling the library with candles, and then poking candles into every dark shadow that remained, I found a very incongruous collection of a score of books. There is not one book in that collection newer than 500 years old, and this find would be classed as monumental in any part of Avilund. The books all display some evidence of their venerable age, but are well preserved for the most part. Given the amount of rain this country seems to experience, I was surprised to find only a little bit of black and green mold in some of the books. Certainly, this is a well constructed building, to admit none of the rain that assaults it so. In fact, whilst searching the library, I could hear the rain thrumming the roof high above, as the ceiling of the library must be the roof of the House.

The books are all written in Old Imperial, as one could well imagine. Again, however, they are interspersed with much language that is unknown to me, and several are in fact entirely obscure to me, being written in a language that not only can I not read, but cannot determine the language or even the alphabet base. Perhaps they are written in the apocryphal *Angelic* or *Devilish* or *Demonic*. I do not know. I have made copies of many of the characters and words, including the titles of the books herein.

I have now spent countless hours pouring through these books, and I do not know where to begin describing what I have found. I shall save it for later. Though I have had a physically undemanding day, I am still weak from my journey and exposure, and still suffer a phlegmatism that would have many patients bed ridden. I am hungry, but earlier found another canvas sack of the same shoddy provisions that I encountered yesterday. The apples alone I ate, and the wine, again, was fantastic. It alone sustains me.

October 25?

I can now name 162 Saints. I have endured the Consumption of St. Belarus, The Immolation of St. Donovan, and the Crucifixion of St. William. As one could well imagine, the Scion will not admit company on these most obscure, but surely, most holy of days.

I have been able to catch Numble most days. After my discovery in the library, and the subsequent discovery of my replenished, though spare, provisions and wood, I realized that Numble had every intention of sneaking in, day by day, and supplying me without the courtesy of salutations, let alone consideration for the furtherance of my appointed

task. So, the next day, I sat in the kitchen where he left the previous provisions and wood. On this occasion, he brought his bundle only as far as the foyer.

The next day, I camped out in the foyer, and in a dark corner at that. Sure enough, he came sneaking in through the door after his long and noisy fumbling of keys.

“Good day, Numble!” I said, as I came springing out of my hiding. I quite surprised Mr. Numble, and he started into a bout of coughing that sounded something like boots prodding through a thick and sludgy bog. His knees knocked and creaked all the time, so that he produced a veritable cacophony of phlegmatic and rattling noises that I am sure rang through all the obsidian-black streets of this sunless acropolis. I smiled, probably for the first time in days.

“Or rather” I continued “Good night, or whatever time of day it is in this perdurable pitch!” By this time I had crossed the small foyer to the man, who was still in the middle of his violent, barking throes, and was unable to take my proffered hand, or to make any other gestures of greeting for that matter. It mattered not to me at this time, proper manners and conduct being all distant memories to me now.

“I see you are quite unwell today, my good man. I hope you will recover, and bring me to see the Scion before you expire, good sir!” I continued, through his hacking and gurgling and rattling and shaking. I folded my arms behind my back, smiled, and rocked back and forth on my heels, watching to see if the octogenarian would die or not. He did not.

He began by waving one finger at me in a very dismissive manner. He was nearly doubled over at this time, one hand on one knee, keeping him from falling over altogether. He cranked back his clicking, skeletal neck, and brought up his bony face over one shoulder to shoot a long, contemptuous look at me. Clearing his throat, he said “Yew! not go a step past this threshold on the Consumption of St. Belarus, you Saintless beggar!” He gave the sack of food and the small pile of sticks that he had dropped a languorous kick, and turned to leave.

“Good Sir!” I ejaculated. “Please! My apologies for an ungraceful salute, Sir. I wish only to carry out my duties, and to rid myself of your charge and dutiful care.” Yes, I had quite changed my posture and position. I now felt bad, mostly because the man who I had so satisfyingly surprised held my fate in my hands, but seeing the man kick at the pile of sticks so weakly made me pity him again.

He clucked his tongue, by way of answering me, and made his leave, locking me in again.

For the next couple of days it was the same, though he expected me, and gave me new observances to learn before quitting my company and locking me in. Tonight, or whenever, I decided that I would make my leave of this place, and look around a bit. For the first time in all my days, I am quite finished reading, having taken in all the words I

know of the various books that I have found here. I confess that I know that I should make the best of my time incarcerated here, and make a complete study of these antiquated tomes, but I am now weary of Dunvegan House, and its unflagging dust and cobwebs. I have found a total of sixty eight windows in this great house, and sixty seven of them are nailed shut. The last is on the second floor, and it looks out from a small bedroom in which there are enough sheets that have escaped the moths, and I have made a rope of them, and plan to descend.

October 26-27?

I have been exploring, and nearly forfeited my life for it. I will not be exploring again, as I have gained one doorman, of a stamp, to keep an unsleeping eye upon me.

After I had slept, and woke at a nebulous time, I mustered my courage to go exploring in the Valdenwail. I packed up my back pack with what little food I have been able to keep, several candles, and one bottle of the excellent wine of this place (I have had a couple of bottles come my way with antediluvian labels upon them which read "Valdenholme Vinyard" with dates varying from 888 to 1207, though surely they did not contain the original contents).

I pried open the second floor window, and made the rope fast to the large bed, and made my descent. Again, I met stygian blackness on the street below, but I could tell by the feel beneath my feet that I was upon ancient and undisturbed cobbles. I had one candle alight, and it cast enough light for me to follow one wall on my right, though I could not see anything to my left, nor a roof above me. Clearly, though, the street had but a single layer of roof above; I could clearly hear the rain sounding off above me. It made a sound that hinted to me that the roof might be covered with slates.

I followed the grey stone wall on the right for quite some time. The wall is made of enormous blocks, the smallest of which having no less than four square feet of face. Though there is some mold at the base of it, there is almost no other vegetation besides. The streets are a little dusty, though for the most part free of debris. I should add that the smell of the place was not as musty as I would have expected, but rather, like dry earth after a long drought.

For several hundred paces did I follow that grey monolithic Dunvegan House to my right. At a few points in the journey, I happened upon great stone pillars that came upon me like ghosts, from the darkness to my left, as I wandered cautiously along. They were all meticulously cut from blocks six feet exactly on all sides, and stacked higher than my candle would illuminate (I could see the bottom half of the fourth block). These blocks, though precisely carved and placed, lack the illuminated friezes that adorn much of the older masonry I have encountered in the Valdenwail, which makes me think that they are much newer additions to the place. Perhaps these are the columns which support the newer thoroughfare-ceilings of which I was told. I cannot see to the top of them, so I cannot say for sure.

Now, it is foolish to go about exploring in just about any place without some way to keep track of where you have been, and the Valdenwail is perhaps the worst place of all for such a journey. But as I have said, I have found scores of candles in Dunvegan House, and I have borrowed them for the purpose of finding my way back. At each intersection that I came to, I lit a new candle and left it burning there. Of course, I have lit the largest candles first, and I knew that I had about 6 hours, no more, to spend at large in the Valdenwail.

I was unable to follow a straight course through that dateless darkness for more than a few hundred paces, so labyrinthine is the Valdenwail. The place is very much a covered city. Though I walk on what are certainly streets, every avenue is covered entirely by the slate roof, supported by the huge pillars.

The streets are of ancient cobbles, and there are elevated walking stones to the sides of the streets for those afoot, while horses and conveyances would be able to rumble past at any speed down the middle. Very few streets in Waldheim are constructed such, but here, even the smallest of alleys down which I have lost myself, I found this same sound and considerate construction. There are portcullised holes in the streets that most certainly lead to a sewer network of some variety. It makes my head swim to think of the darkness-under-darkness of a sewer-realm which may exist beneath this enduring blackness. It is a further marvel to me that this most antiquated acropolis would have a peerless infrastructure to match its peerless prodigious volume. But, if I were to imagine this place full of the teeming peoples it could certainly accommodate, I should not be surprised that the architects of this place have included such details.

For the most part, what I have seen of the Valdenwail is a multitude of large row-houses, at least 3 stories tall, perhaps much taller in places (I can use the sound of the rain above to roughly estimate heights). They are sound, and most are covered in elegant details and convoluted friezes. They are each a marvel, and any one of them would be the pride of any street in Waldheim, but here, where stunning, enduring beauty is the status quo, they are legion.

As I passed the doors of the larger buildings, some would remind me of the door to Dunvegan House, and I got to thinking, "How many other messengers are entombed behind those taciturn doors, their charge failed, their bones and undelivered messages now so much dust upon the lonely floor?" This descended me into a melancholy. The thought of dying of protracted incarceration in the Valdenwail is too much to bear. The situation is all the more woeful, as this is a prison of matchless historical significance, and under any other circumstances, I, a Distinguished Graduate of the Seminary of St. Ignatius, should think I would have loved to retire to such a place and spend all my days studying the limitless statuary, friezes, frescoes, tapestries, and other objects too numerous in variety and quantity to name herein, until I pass. Surely, this is the Antiquarian's Dream, to be trapped in the very Heart of the Empire of Men, with nothing but time and wits. And here I am, spending my time wandering aimlessly, taking in the atramentous spectacle like a byway farmer wandering the streets of Waldheim. For shame. I feel as though I have been tested...

My mood changed, though. I rounded one corner, and down a long alley, I espied a pale light being cast upon the cobbles. I hurried towards the light, and was rewarded when I arrived at it with a slight breeze upon my face, and the light of day, shrouded by cloud though it was, coming from a broad and slit-like rend in that steadfast darkness, somewhere very high up; I had to crane my neck upwards to take it in.

It was quite some time before my eyes adjusted, so long had it been since I had seen so much light. While I squinted and worked my lids, my ears took in the sound of the ocean crashing against the rocks, somewhere very far off. The smell of the sea was once again strong in my nares, and it filled me with strength, to again smell something organic, something not dust-covered and forgotten. There was also a low moaning, and though it was disconcerting at first, it turned out to be the wind blowing down from that opening, and into the Valdenwail, where it sang with many voices as it sped down many avenues and alleyways, shrinking as it did so. I was so refreshed to have my senses filled that the horror of my incarceration was nearly forgotten. I invoked the name of Saint Lorrigan at that time; my escape from the imperishable dusty darkness seeming an allegory to his living escape from his own unfounded grave.

By this time, I had adjusted my eyes, and took in the sight. I stood at the base of a most immutable bulwark. The blocks here were ten feet long and five feet high, and they stretched as far to the left and right as I could see. I must have been standing on some rim-road which ran along the outer, seaward wall of the Valdenwail. It was the longest bit of road I have seen in this maze of hoary stone. It was about sixty feet high, which I estimated by way of counting blocks, and at first, seemingly insurmountable. The light issued forth from an opening, presumably along the battlements at which I stood at the base of, and the opening was only forty to fifty feet wide, and then the ubiquitous darkness continued. But looking to my right and left, and screwing up my face so as to see a little farther, I noticed similar patches of light at great distances from me in either direction.

Making for the light to my left, I noticed that the streets here were not so dry and dusty. Rather, they had a very earthy smell to them, and were covered in slightly phosphorescent fungus that, when seen while standing in the now-punctuated darkness, gave off enough light to provide an outline of the ancient stone around me. It was fantastic, though spectral, and I confess that I moved along with some concern that I was walking towards some proverbial light, making my Transition through the Ghostly Realm. But then, I have not been eating or sleeping well of late, have I?

Before I came to the light, having traveled some hundred and fifty paces, I found an opening to my right – a very large archway with an open door. I peeked my head inside, and found a capacious stairway leading up. The stairs were a spiral, and ten men could easily have marched shoulder to shoulder up them. They were solid stone the entire way up, even though my circuitous journey brought me many times about; such is the architecture of the Valdenwail. At length, I climbed the last broad stair, and found

myself on a slippery, mossy landing, facing another large and unobstructed archway, and beyond, the pale grey of the ceiling of the world.

I was even more elated as I crossed that threshold, and felt the sting of the full wind on my face, its autumnal chill waking me from a dream, its saltiness like a breath taken after a long plunge. I should say it was nearly eventide, of what day I am not sure. The sun was a pale circle of lighter grey in the darker clouds. The Harbour of the Valdenwail was before me, and the violent sea beyond it was the same colour and temper as the sky, so grey and cold and roiling were they both.

The Harbour is perfect. It is a circle perhaps two miles in radius, with the Valdenwail making up one half of its circumference, and a menacing and toothy-looking craggy ridge the other. There is a small aperture in that natural wall, perhaps one hundred yards high (though it is tough to tell at this distance, and I have proven myself a most terrible judge of measurement in this confusion-inspiring realm), opposite the Valdenwail, through which a couple large ships might sail. Even from this distance, I can see that a great citadel sits atop this natural arch, so that no ship could pass unwelcome into that Harbour.

Looking down over the substantial battlements, I could take in the serenity of the Harbour below. Though the ocean raged beyond the wall, the Harbour was calm. It must be horribly and unfathomably deep, so black are those still waters. The natural precipice upon which the Valdenwail sits rises at least one hundred yards from the face of the water, and nearly straight up, until the huge blocks of the outer wall are found. At the base of this escarpment, growing out of the sea like hundreds of gnarly and broken teeth, are smaller stone protrusions; the remnants of a slowly receding cliff. They are worn to every shape thinkable, and make old things look new, so moss-covered and weather-eaten are they. And yet, upon most of them are small buildings; small only because of my great distance from them, and their relative scale beside the vast walls of the Valdenwail. Surely, those are small fortresses upon those stalagmites of the Harbour, and they are as mossy as the geologically uncertain protrusions upon which they sit. Many have vast and nearly impossible arches spanning the distance between them, so that many comprise small networks between themselves with these graceful bridges. And still many others have only partial bridges which lead out over open water. Time does pass, even here.

I have espied at least three arches that lead from some of the closer protrusions, upon which sit larger and taller fortresses; arches that lead to the cliff face upon which the Valdenwail sits. There are bridges upon them that lead to the belly of this behemolithic acropolis, and, presumably, tunnels commencing therefrom, which worm their way up, unseen and unremembered.

I was shaking my head, trying to take it all in. I was again lost in the complexity and the vastness of the Valdenwail, and was again feeling the sorrow of such a monument of Man's Industry remaining all but vacant for centuries unnumbered. I had already taken for granted the feeling of the open air, and the quality of the shrouded light of the sun, when it was all sundered again. As I leaned precariously over the bulwark, I heard a door open far to my left, at the opposite end of the open portion of the battlement from which I

emerged. I could not see the origin of that bone-chilling noise, poised such as I was, with a great stone obstacle between I and it, and I made no effort at first to change this, so numb with fright was I. I heard one great armoured footfall, and knew what I would see coming out of that black portal to my left. I righted myself, and as my face slid past the stone battlement, the mailed sentinel that I was expecting did come into view by inches. He was perhaps forty feet away from me, and walking ponderously forward. His mail was similar to the other sentinels I have seen; it was bronze, and every square inch was covered in detail. This armour was quite green with moss, though, and the legs the more so. It carried a great shield and a great maul, also bronze, also detailed, mossy and green. And it wielded the same oppressive will of his fellows.

I remember quickly thinking “One open door in the whole decrepit City, and...stupid Stephan! Of course! There are no open doors in this place, unless they are opened apurpose. That thing had come that way, and must have been coming back! No more open doors for me, thank you!”

I knew at once that he viewed and labeled me as an intruder, and that he was coming to apprehend me. I made a mental plea, but it was met with the same obstinate wall of will. There was nothing for it but to run. Surely, I thought, no one in such armour would catch one as unencumbered as I.

I headed back to the black opening to the right, and back down the wide stone steps as fast as I could. In fact, I went faster than I could, and I went for a nasty tumble down several steps after slipping on some of the mossy growth that has accumulated in this part of the Valdenwail. I struck my head, and blacked out...

One could well imagine my horror upon waking, alone in the dark, a fire in my head, and the taste of blood in my mouth. It was very dark; pitch, I thought. But, it just took my eyes some time to adjust. There was the same pale light above me that I had just been making my escape in. And just then I heard the sound of heavily armoured feet above me, perhaps a few steps away. I had not been out as long as I thought, though in those few short seconds I lived a long story of horror that has probably cost me a year of my allotted time in this World. I scrambled to my feet, and made my way more cautiously down those steps, descending into perfect darkness as I did so. It was a long way down, before I hit, unexpectedly, awkwardly, and with another ungraceful fall, the bottom. This time, my chin hit the unyielding stone, and several of my teeth are chipped for it.

This, still, did not stop me. Laying prostrate in the bottom of the stairs, I was facing the opening, and saw that same pale light that brought me here in the first place, beyond the threshold. I was back at street level, and though what little light there was I would soon lose, it gave me a bearing. I got up, dashed out into the street, and turned right. I made one quick listen in the archway, and heard the ponderous report from the bronze feet. It had come only about half way down the stair.

I dashed off, heading towards the next bit of open battlement, which should have been a couple hundred yards away. It was further, and as I proceeded along, I slowed my pace,

and let my mind work again. So full of fright I was, that I had made a wrong turn after leaving the archway without thinking, and had just now run hundreds of yards THE WRONG DIRECTION! Certainly, I did not pay enough attention to Janvermin and his craft.

I knew that to try and find my path back by any other direction from that which I just came would be futile. There are absolutely no parallel or straight avenues in the Valdenwail, and though logic would dictate that I could head into the darkness of the Valdenwail for a block, and the head to the left, it would not service my cause in this maze. There was nothing to do but run back, and hopefully pass the archway a second time, before the Sentinel made the street.

I ran as fast as I ever have, for exactly four paces. My fourth pace found my foot perched precariously along the edge of an uncommonly large and protruding cobblestone, and I immediately doubled over at the ankle, and subsequently found myself sprawled out on the stone for the third time in less than a minute or so. I landed mostly on my left wrist, and now have a broken wrist to add to my list of injuries as well.

I thought about giving up, and letting the thing come to me, but just then I had, for the first time in my young life, a Sign. As I have mentioned, the stones in this long avenue are covered in a glowing moss which provides some little light. As I lay there, my head lolling to the side, my hope diminishing as my pain grew in my limbs, I looked to my right, where now was a row of the large stone houses, opposite the great bulwark to my left. All had a pale glow from the lichen, but one wall had a cluster of brighter, greenish-yellow lichens that was a perfect replica of Caanan's Cross. I cursed. I lolled my head to the left, and there, in a large sconce in the bulwark, was a likeness of St. Caanan, glowing like a lantern, though I could see no lichen upon his loathsome likeness. I cursed and spat.

"Not today, Herald of Woe!" I uttered beneath my breath. "I will not provide your entertainment today!" And I was up and on my way, hobbling as best as I could, back towards whatever fate awaited me at the stair arch.

My defiance of Caanan might have been enough, but just barely. As I was hobbling past the black doorway, the armoured form stepped from it like a spectre, one hand outstretched for me. It could not have missed me by more than an inch. I could feel its great will demanding me to stop, but I was able to put it out of my mind, and continue on.

Though I was traveling only about half as fast as a man can briskly walk, it was fast enough to put distance between me and the sentinel. I made my way back to the first opening in the bulwark that I had found, and plunged into the darkness of the streets of the Valdenwail. I was heading down the alleyway that brought me here, but to my horror, I noticed that in my excitement, I had not placed a candle at the next intersection, after my discovery of the light. This was another mistake that good Janvermin would have never permitted.

I came to a pitch black intersection, the pale light now distant behind me. I could hear the unrelenting pace of the Sentinel as it lumbered along. At the end of the long alley, I could see the silhouette of the thing as it rounded the corner. I had some time to figure out which way I had come. I walked a few blind paces into the darkness, clenching my teeth in my bloody mouth half in pain, half in anticipation of another fall and more pain. I was lucky. I found myself on some flat ground, on one of the wider and more worn of the thoroughfares of the Valdenwail. I had no candle at this point, and was entering the heart of obsidian blackness, my hands outstretched, my left leg limping along behind me, blood trickling down the back of my throat. My eyes must have been as wide as saucers, so wanting for light was I.

And I found it. As I hobbled along, I did finally notice a light off to my left. It was very distant, and I headed towards it gingerly. I did in fact find one of my candles, and though the Sentinel had made ground on me whilst I clamoured in the darkness, I was easily able to outpace the thing back to my appointed accommodations. I was then met with my next challenge.

Though I am not known as a man who does not think things through (in fact, I have been accused of quite the opposite in my time), I did leave a large, and insurmountable problem for myself in the poor laying of this plan for adventure. As I approached the last candle, now burnt nearly to the stone of the street outside of Dunvegan House (a place, by all that is madness, I was elated to see again), I noticed the dangling rope of sheets hanging by the light of the candle, right where I left it. Now, I am a lean man, and have had many long days toiling at the more bodily tasks that the Seminary demanded of me during my Investiture. But I am by no means strong under the best of circumstances. Whether I could have climbed that rope in perfect health, I will never know. I can say with certainty that I was unable to climb it after my starving incarceration, and with a sprained ankle and broken wrist, though Ignatius knows that I tried. I tried, in fact, until I was in tears with pain and desperation. I think I actually tried to use my teeth to replace my lame hand at one point, for the last thing I saw by the light of the dying candle outside the prison I was so desperately trying to enter again, was a very bloody bedsheet.

I was spared only by my ears. I took a moment to pause, and catch my breath, and I heard a resounding clicking and whooping coming towards me from somewhere within the reticent blackness of the Valdenwail. Numb. I blew out the candle, and waited and listened.

Numb it was, sure enough. I heard him get nearer and nearer, and before long I saw the light of the small candle that he bore before him. He passed like a ghost, albeit a rambling and noisy ghost that looks capable of dying a second death at any moment, at the end of the street upon which I hid, and I heard him fumble with his mess of keys. He made entry into the House. I paused, then followed in behind him, doing the best I could to be quiet, though I hobbled like a war veteran. I managed to find a chair in the corner of the parlour that was somewhat obfuscated, and pretended to sleep. He passed back out of the House, seemingly none-the-wiser.

Just as I thought I was clear of danger, I heard the diligent lumbering of the Sentinel as it walked up to the entrance of Dunvegan House, just as Numble was leaving. Surely the two saw each other, and indeed, Numble stayed for quite some time on that porch, undoubtedly having an unnatural conversation in the voiceless manner of those terrible Sentinels. Numble finally let out a gurgling laugh, and clicked off into the lightless labyrinth.

The Sentinel is still standing on that porch as I write this, and has not moved a finger.

Mid November

I am having a lucid moment just now, and feel like writing. It is madness to be kept here in the darkness, eating one soft apple a day, and drinking some wine which once tasted so sweet. I would not be surprised if they have switched the brand, finding that it is the only thing that I consume regularly, and I would not be surprised if I am just plain sick of drinking it day after day, but it is now a noxious swill to me. And it is sweet, and leaves a pang in my broken teeth.

I took a look in a mirror the other night (for I shall cease use of the word 'day' henceforth), and was terrified. I have lost a considerable amount of what little weight I began this charge with, and though I let out a chuckle at the thought, it is no funny matter that I now have Numble's build. My wrist is a terrible swollen black and blue and blotchy white mess, and my eyes are sunken quite deep into my head. My garments are a reflection of my withered flesh. They are torn and sullied in a number of ways, and I am sure they smell terrible, though the smell of all but dust is forgotten to me.

While I think of it, I shall say that I hope that Janvermin has more wisdom than he does patience. I will not be delivering my message to the Scion, and I will not be leaving the Valdenwail. I hope Vermin has left. I hope he is alive.

(Later entry, undated, quite scribbly)

I will brook no more Exonerations of St. Jack Ass, or Flatulence of St. Orifice. I must find an end to this incarceration of darkness. The Bishop was right about the Scion. He is mad!

(Much scribbling and nonsense follows for several pages. At one point, a list of 245 Saints follows, though some are obviously falsely named, such as St. Jack Ass, who is mentioned here for the second time.)

January 9, 1747

I am certain of the date, though I am sure that it was given to me as a form of medicine. I have been raving about the time for months now, and I am sure that Numble, though likely given orders to tell me nothing of the date, let a little detail slip. He was mentioning another obscure Saint, and the reason for the furtherance of my delay. I took

no notice of the name of the event. But then he said something that I did catch, as I am sure he intended.

“Yesterday was the Investiture of Saint Ignatius, and the Collegium Founding, in case you’ve lost track of time, my guest” he said, and started into a bout of coughing and rattling again, and headed for the door. I awoke from my madness in that instant, and rose quickly to follow him to the door.

“So it is January the ninth! By all the Saints, a new year has begun!” I nearly wept. I was happy and sad, and malnourished and saw a glimmer of hope, for some reason. I saw some spark that hinted to me that my deliverance was near. I looked to Numble, and I asked “What is tomorrow, good sir?”

“Nuthin” was his curt reply. He made his way out as unceremoniously as ever.

I will meet with the Scion tomorrow. Tonight, I must clean myself as best I can, and mend these garments. I know there are some implements of tailoring in the butler’s den.

January 10.

I write this from outside the Gate of the Valdenwail. The diminutive door in the great double arch of the Gates has only recently slammed shut behind me, and the trio of Sentinels have reeled back their oppressive wills from within my head. I am over the crest, beneath the great fork-towers and arch under which I camped for days. I shall only camp one night here this time. I am on my way home, finally.

The day started as usual. I was wandering around in the candle light of Dunvegan House, though with a little more excitement than usual. Numble came in with his usual pomp, which is to say, none. I confronted him eagerly.

Numble was not carrying his usual sack of rotten food and faggot of soggy wood. He wore a pair of grey and hoary gloves which I have not seen him wearing before. He saw me, coughed and choked and roiled and creaked and groaned for some time, and then addressed me.

“You have a message from the Prelate of Saint Ignatius, you say?” he inquired. I nodded. He likes short answers, and I decided to spare my pomp for those that matter and who are more affected than insulted by it, if such people there are in this place. “Follow” he said, and he lit another candle and made his way out the door. He stopped on the doorstep outside, and turned back in, to see that I was following. That is the nicest gesture that he ever made towards me.

Follow I did. The first thing I noticed was the absence of the Sentinel at my doorstep. I have not thought on it for quite some time, and I must confess that I am not sure if he left days or months after my roguish journey.

Numble lead me through miles of veiled street, through avenues even broader than before, and through great gates in thick walls. Back through time we seemed to journey; the architecture became more simple and prodigious as we journeyed, and the choking dustiness seemed to hit a peak somewhere partway through that twilight journey. At a couple points, we passed by streets down which I could see daylight shining, and at one point, we even walked through an open-air garden. There was a great opening above, and though it dripped at its edges from a recent rain, the sun was shining through as bright as I have seen it in this Ecclesiarchy. Though the journey was filled with greater wonders and mysteries, and seemed to grow more optimistic as we proceeded, I should add that we did not encounter another soul on that journey, nor even heard or saw a sign of one.

Finally, we arrived at a great manor home, similar to Dunvegan House in its opulence and size. It was covered by the same road-roof as the rest of the Valdenwail, but there were torches burning at all corners of the place, and several lights on inside. The sight of bright light in those windows was so encouraging that I gave a veritable laugh, and straightened my weatherworn jacket, and propped my soiled hat. I noticed that standing in one curtain was a silhouette of a man, with his hand over his eyes, likely straining to see into the darkness through the panes of glass. He must have seen us, for as we approached, he turned away.

I should boast that I knew I would not meet the Scion, as soon as we approached the main door to this House (Grimwood House, Numble called it). There were no Sentinels around, and I am sure that a meeting with Him would have been preceded by a scrutiny of those voiceless devils-in-bronze. There was none.

Numble rattled right up to the door, rapped it three times, and withdrew, hanging his head low as he did. My heart was racing, and I clutched the sealed letter in my hand tightly as I heard someone deftly turn a half dozen latches and bolts. The door opened, and though the light that issued forth immediately blinded me, I soon found that I was standing face to face with a man.

The man was about my height, being not too tall, and was slender, though not as slender as this messenger in my emaciated condition such as it is now. He wore a yellow gown with no markings at all. The man had a face like a yellow stone that has been polished by aeons of tides washing over it. His skin was taught and flawless, though not the hue of those I am used to. He had great bright blue eyes, and for hair, a single lock issuing forth from a knot at the upper occipital region of his skull, and this was a venerable silver white. I cannot guess that man's age, but if I were forced to put some borders around his age, I should say between twenty and two hundred.

He looked young, except for the silver hair, though the look in his eyes was so full of wisdom that I thought he carried a thousand years behind them. I could not look him in the eye for long. He wore an expression as gentle and benign as I can imagine, though he looked somewhat troubled. It was he who spoke first.

“I am Doctor Gideon. You are Envoy Dunmorrow, and I understand you have been waiting to carry out your charge for quite some time.” His voice was deep and level and carried the most intoned understanding I have encountered in a Human voice. “You should know that we have not kept you waiting for months on end for the purpose of testing your resolve.”

I was curious that he mentioned ‘testing’. Since I have awakened from my madness, I have long contemplated this very issue of ‘testing’. I wondered if the inhabitants of this place were testing me by placing books in Dunvegan House to see if I would take the time to read them and study them. I wondered if the single open window was left to see if I would make a thorough examination of the place, and also to see if I would take the chance of an exploration of the Valdenwail. Perhaps they left the door to the battlements open to see if I would take it. Perhaps it has all been a test, and though I have not made a flawless effort, having descended most ashamedly into madness for some time, I have not failed, for here I am talking with Doctor Gideon.

I shall make a quick note about what I knew of the Doctor. I half expected to meet him. If there are any rumours and gossip coming out of the Valdenwail, it all centres around this enigmatic paragon. He is the personal physician to the Scion, and also his most trusted advisor. He is the only resident of the Valdenwail that comes to the Conclave that is accessible, and it is this one man who all the Upper Clergy, from Bishops to Prelates, of nearly every Saint at Conclave, attempt to engage and sway. Having met him in his own home, I can now see what a wise choice the Scion has made in this man. As I have said, he is a physical dubiety, appearing so old and young at once. But his manner and bearing would make the most puissant diplomat feel like a stammering lout, though he is full of such understanding that none could feel wronged by any conversation with the man.

And, he answers nothing.

He continued in his explanation. “You must understand that this place, the Valdenwail, is the very last refuge of Ceremony and Tradition. We are the last guardians of our beleaguered Faith, and though many of our Observances may seem antiquated, if not contrived, to outsiders, each one is as important as Conclave. We do not waver in our Venerations, as dictated by the Canonical Calendar, for any event or person, though fire may fall from the sky, or kings show up at our gates.” He smiled a troubled but understanding smile, and I was disarmed. I made a stammering dismissal of any charges of ill treatment, and thanked him a dozen times for a dozen small courtesies, and finally we got to the business at hand.

“Good Sir” I began. I was about to deliver my prepared oration, when I was cut off, again, from doing so. No one in this Ecclesiarchy seems interested in hearing my carefully prepared allocution. The Doctor smiled, and brought his hands up, to make the same gesture that parents use to tell their children to ‘keep it down’.

“I know you have come to deliver a message from the Seat of your Cannon, to the Scion, and likely to the Scion and no other. I am loath to tell you that I must put a terrible decision before you; to deliver the message to me, or to none. None may hold host with the Scion in this Age, I regretfully say to you. I am the Scion’s most trusted assistant, however, and I swear to you that I will deliver this message, swiftly and without compromising the most sanctimonious seal found thereupon. You can trust to me, or bring your message back undelivered.” He smiled. I placed the letter in his hand. He gracefully bowed, and placed it in his robe most carefully.

The hospitality of Grimwood House was a great improvement over Dunvegan House. I was brought in and fed a hearty though plain meal of fresh breads and cheese, and once again, fantastic wine. We sat sipping the blood-warming wine, while he listened to me talk about the outside world. He was hungry for any information that I could provide, and I confess that I let slip a good many rumours and privileged information that I should not have. The man has a way of listening to your words before you even speak them, and he seems to steer my words through some guile or strength of will that I cannot understand. He said nothing for several hours, while I ran on, unchecked, about affairs abroad.

Now that I am sitting here beneath the weather-beaten arch of the fork towers, I realize that perhaps my tongue was loosened with several tools; a long and lonesome incarceration with no one to converse with, bottles of excellent wine, a hearty meal after a long fast. These are excellent tools with which to get one to speak. Though I feel like I may have been falsely played, and harshly used, I still can’t help but feel a great exhilaration at being free of this letter, free of the timeless walls and unceasing darkness and solitary incarceration. Though the rain is falling upon me, and the wind once again stabbing at me, and though I have a long and perilous journey ahead of me, the worst is over, and I am now bound for home.
